

The Violent Effects of Apex Corruption

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Abstract

We document that *apex* corruption scandals—corrupt acts implicating top-level politicians—cause immediate and persistent increases in violent protests across Latin America. Using a panel of 176 corruption scandals across 23 countries from 2008 to 2018, merged with daily protest counts, we establish three facts. The daily count of violent protests increases by about 0.2 standard deviations in the month immediately after the scandal. The effect appears within a week of the scandal, and remains positive even 4 months later. The magnitude of the effect scales sharply with the political rank of the implicated agent: scandals involving sitting presidents show effects 2–3 times larger than those involving Governors or Congress members. Our findings identify a high-frequency, high-magnitude channel through which corruption shapes the political environment in democracies.

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1 Introduction

Political violence is among the most consequential outcomes a democracy can experience. Civil unrest disrupts economic activity, displaces investment, and—when met with state violence in return—erodes the social contract that legitimizes the regime. An influential economic literature has linked political violence to economic shocks (Miguel et al. 2004; McGuirk and Burke 2020), to commodity rents and network structure (König et al. 2017), and—in the recent comparative work—to abrupt withdrawals of foreign assistance (Rohner et al. 2026). The contribution of political shocks to events that change citizens’ beliefs about who governs them has received considerably less attention. In this paper, we argue that disclosures of apex corruption are one such shock, and that the behavioral consequences for political violence are large, immediate, and persistent.

Citizens’ perceptions of corruption prevalence have risen in the past two decades (Cantoni et al. 2024). Moreover, corruption scandals associated to *apex* politicians have drawn more attention from news outlets in recent years (Rivera et al. 2024); perhaps unsurprisingly due to the expansion of social media, which reduces the cost of diffusing information and enables news outlets to reach broader audiences (Enikolopov et al. 2018; Tufekci 2024). While exposing corruption scandals on news outlets can have positive desired effects, such as political accountability or crackdowns of corruption networks (Ferraz and Finan 2011; Arias et al. 2019, 2022), it can also have negative undesired effects on democratic values (Ajzenman 2021; Rivera et al. 2024) and away from the polling booths. Public exposure of malfeasance by sitting officials changes what citizens believe about who governs them and about the rules under which the government operates. The most consequential corruption-related political moments of the last decade, such as Brazil’s Lava Jato¹, were mobilization events, not electoral ones.

We document that apex corruption—corrupt acts implicating top-level politicians—triggers immediate and persistent increases in violent protests across Latin American democracies. Using a panel of 176 corruption scandals across 23 countries from 2008 to 2018, merged with daily protest counts from the Mass Mobilization (MM) project (Clark and Regan 2016), we establish three facts. First, the daily count of violent protests increases by about 0.2 standard deviations in the month immediately after the scandal. The overall count of protests and the count of peaceful protests, however, remain largely unaffected. Second, the effect appears within a week of the scandal break out, and remains positive even 4 months later, relative to the immediate month before the scandal. Third, the magnitude of the effect scales sharply with the political rank of the implicated agent: scandals involving sitting presidents show effects 2–3 times larger than those involving Governors or members

¹See [this video](#) for more information on the scandal.

of Congress. Scandals involving Supreme Court justices, lower judiciary, and other non-apex officials leave protest patterns broadly unchanged.

2 Method

2.1 Study Design and Measures

To conduct the empirical analyses we exploit the randomness of corruption scandal breakthroughs in Latin American news outlets between 2008 and 2018. In particular, we use a stacked difference-in-differences design in which we compare the evolution of protest occurrences in countries with scandals to those without scandals. Our analysis dataset is created by: (i) Scraping the Twitter accounts from news outlets in Latin America to identify the calendar date in which a scandal in a given country is first reported², (ii) create an event-window of $T \in \{30, 120\}$ days before and after the scandal, (iii) merge the country-day count of protests from the MM data to create a ‘scandal-protest’ for a given country in a given calendar-date window, and lastly, (iv) append all such scandal-protest datasets to build the analysis dataset.

The MM dataset is available for the period 1990–2020, and it includes information on the date, size, and location of any episodes where 50 or more protesters publicly demonstrate against the State. If a protest lasts X days, we code the occurrence of a protest at date $t, t + 1, \dots, t + X - 1$. Additionally, if the same protest is associated with more than one date (e.g., because the news source for the protest cannot accurately identify whether it is a continued or a new protest), then we keep the date of the earliest protest. For a protest to be qualified as “violent”, “[t]he violence could include anything from riotous behavior that destroys property to shooting at the police or military.” Our main outcome is the number of protests occurring in a given country-date. We focus on the years 2008–2018, given that our corruption scandals data is available for those years.

We use Ordinary Least Squares to estimate the following equation³:

$$Y_{c(s)t} = \beta \mathbb{1}\{t \geq \text{Scandal Date}_{c(s)}\} + \alpha_d + \lambda_m + \theta_{cy} \quad (1)$$

where α_d denote day of the week fixed effects, λ_m denote month of the year fixed effects, θ_{cy} denote country-year fixed effects, $\text{Scandal Date}_{c(s)}$ is the date in which corruption scandal s in country c occurs and $Y_{c(s)t}$ denotes the outcome of interest in country c at date t .

²We keep the date of the first news report to (a) be able to estimate the effect of a scoop, and (b) avoid double-counting a scandal due to follow-up news reports on it.

³In the Supplementary Materials we estimate the analogous equation using Poisson Quasimaximum Likelihood to account for the count-nature of the outcome.

To trace dynamics we replace $\mathbb{1}\{t \geq \text{Scandal Date}_{c(s)}\}$ in Equation 1 with a saturated set of bin indicators. At the narrow window ($T = 30$) we use 6-day bins, which strike a balance between the temporal resolution needed to detect a short-horizon response and the within-bin sample size needed to estimate each bin coefficient precisely. At the wide window ($T = 120$) we use 30-day bins. The reference category in each event-study graph is the bin immediately before disclosure ($w_{s,t} \in [-6, -1]$ at the narrow window, $w_{s,t} \in [-30, -1]$ at the wide window).

The identification assumption we rely on for our estimates to be interpreted as causal is that, conditional on country-year, month-of-year, and day-of-week fixed effects, the within-year date of disclosure of a scandal is as-good-as-randomly assigned in relation to the protest baseline of the country. The country-year fixed effects absorb every source of country-year-level confounding such as pre-existing political instability, electoral calendars, or institutional reforms. The day-of-week and month-of-year fixed effects absorb weekly and seasonal cycles in protest activity.

3 Results

3.1 Apex Corruption Raises Violent Protests

Table 1 and Table 2 report the headline estimates of Equation 1 for the four protest outcomes at the narrow (± 30 -day) and wide (± 120 -day) event windows, respectively. At the narrow window, the post-scandal indicator is associated with an increase of 0.025 protests per country-day in the overall count ($p < 0.01$) and 0.016 violent protests per country-day ($p < 0.01$). Relative to the outcome standard deviations in our sample (approximately 0.12 for any protests and 0.08 for violent protests), both estimates correspond to roughly 0.2 standard deviations. At the wide window, the violent-protest coefficient is unchanged in magnitude and remains statistically significant (0.016, $p < 0.05$), while the any-protest and non-violent coefficients are no longer distinguishable from zero. The persistence of the violent-protest effect on the four-month horizon—and the disappearance of the any-protest and non-violent effects—together indicate that what apex corruption mobilizes on the durable horizon is specifically the violent component of protest. The Government Violent Response outcome, which captures episodes in which the state met protesters with violence, exhibits a parallel pattern: insignificant at the narrow window and positive and significant at the wide window (0.011, $p < 0.05$).

Table 1. Apex corruption and protest activity, ± 30 -day window.

	(1) Protests	(2) Violent Protests	(3) Non-Violent Protests	(4) Govt. Violent Response
Post Scandal	0.025** (0.009)	0.016** (0.005)	0.010 (0.008)	0.006 (0.004)
Observations	10736	10736	10736	10736
Number of Scandals	176	176	176	176
R-squared	0.368	0.160	0.473	0.219
Country $\times$ Year FE	✓	✓	✓	✓
SE Cluster	C $\times$ Y $\times$ DB	C $\times$ Y $\times$ DB	C $\times$ Y $\times$ DB	C $\times$ Y $\times$ DB

Notes. OLS estimates of Equation 1. An observation is a country-day inside a scandal's event window. All specifications include country-by-year, day-of-week, and month-of-year fixed effects. Standard errors (in parentheses) are clustered at the country-by-year-by-day-bin (C $\times$ Y $\times$ DB) level. Significance: * 5%, ** 1%, *** 0.1%.

Table 2. Apex corruption and protest activity, ± 120 -day window.

	(1) Protests	(2) Violent Protests	(3) Non-Violent Protests	(4) Govt. Violent Response
Post Scandal	0.007 (0.010)	0.016* (0.006)	-0.009 (0.007)	0.011* (0.005)
Observations	42657	42657	42657	42657
Number of Scandals	176	176	176	176
R-squared	0.231	0.126	0.300	0.177
Country $\times$ Year FE	✓	✓	✓	✓
SE Cluster	C $\times$ Y $\times$ DB	C $\times$ Y $\times$ DB	C $\times$ Y $\times$ DB	C $\times$ Y $\times$ DB

Notes. OLS estimates of Equation 1. An observation is a country-day inside a scandal's event window. All specifications include country-by-year, day-of-week, and month-of-year fixed effects. Standard errors (in parentheses) are clustered at the country-by-year-by-day-bin (C $\times$ Y $\times$ DB) level. Significance: * 5%, ** 1%, *** 0.1%.

3.2 Dynamics: Immediate and Persistent

Figure 1 traces the dynamic response of violent protests across the two windows. The left panel (± 30 days, 6-day bins) shows pre-scandal coefficients tightly clustered around zero, ruling out a pre-trend;

the first post-scandal bin jumps and remains elevated through the end of the window. The right panel (± 120 days, 30-day bins) re-estimates the dynamics on the wider horizon. The post-scandal coefficients remain positive throughout, with no evidence of decay by the four-month mark. Read together, the two panels document a response that materializes within days of public disclosure and remains active on the horizon over which the political environment of a democracy is meaningfully shaped.

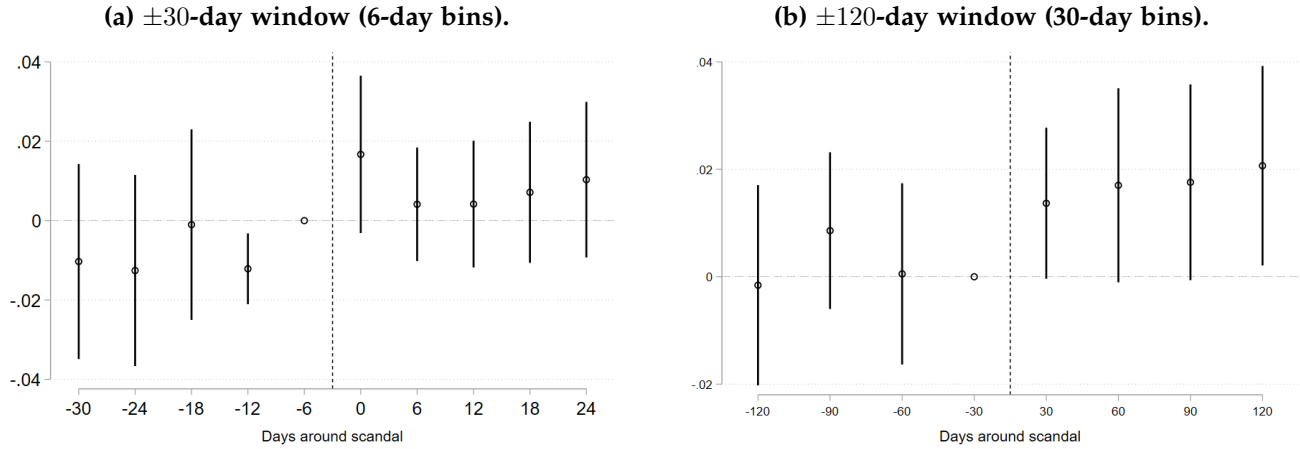


Figure 1. The violent-protest response to apex corruption is immediate and durable. Coefficients on event-time bin dummies from Equation 1 with the post indicator replaced by bin indicators. The omitted reference bin is the one immediately before public disclosure. Vertical bars are 90% confidence intervals constructed from the country-by-year-by-day-bin clustered variance. The outcome in both panels is the daily count of violent protests.

3.3 Heterogeneity by Political Rank of the Implicated Agent

We characterize heterogeneity by re-estimating Equation 1 separately for each of the 176 scandals on its own country's ± 30 -day window, retaining the day-of-week and month-of-year fixed effects. The per-scandal post coefficients $\hat{\beta}_s$ form a cross-scandal distribution that we then summarize against the rank of the implicated official. Figure 2 reports the result in two cuts. The top row contrasts the 45 scandals involving sitting Presidents with the 127 non-Presidential scandals (Governors, members of Congress, judicial officials, and lower officials pooled). The bottom row partitions the non-Presidential subsample into the 27 Other Apex scandals (Governors and members of Congress) and the 100 Other Non-Apex scandals (Supreme Court justices, lower judiciary, and other lower officials).

Across all three outcomes (any protests, violent protests, peaceful protests), the President distribution is shifted upward against the pooled non-Presidential one. The three-way apex partition reveals a near-monotonic gradient: the Other Apex mean lies between the Presidential mean and the

Non-Apex mean, and the Non-Apex mean is statistically indistinguishable from zero. The gradient is sharpest for violent protests, where the Presidential mean is roughly twice the Other Apex mean and roughly four times the Non-Apex mean. The asymmetry is too large to be incidental: were the protest channel symmetric in the rank of the implicated official, the median Supreme Court-justice scandal would be as mobilizing as the median Presidential scandal, and the case for institutional investments concentrated at the apex would be weaker. The data tell the reverse story.

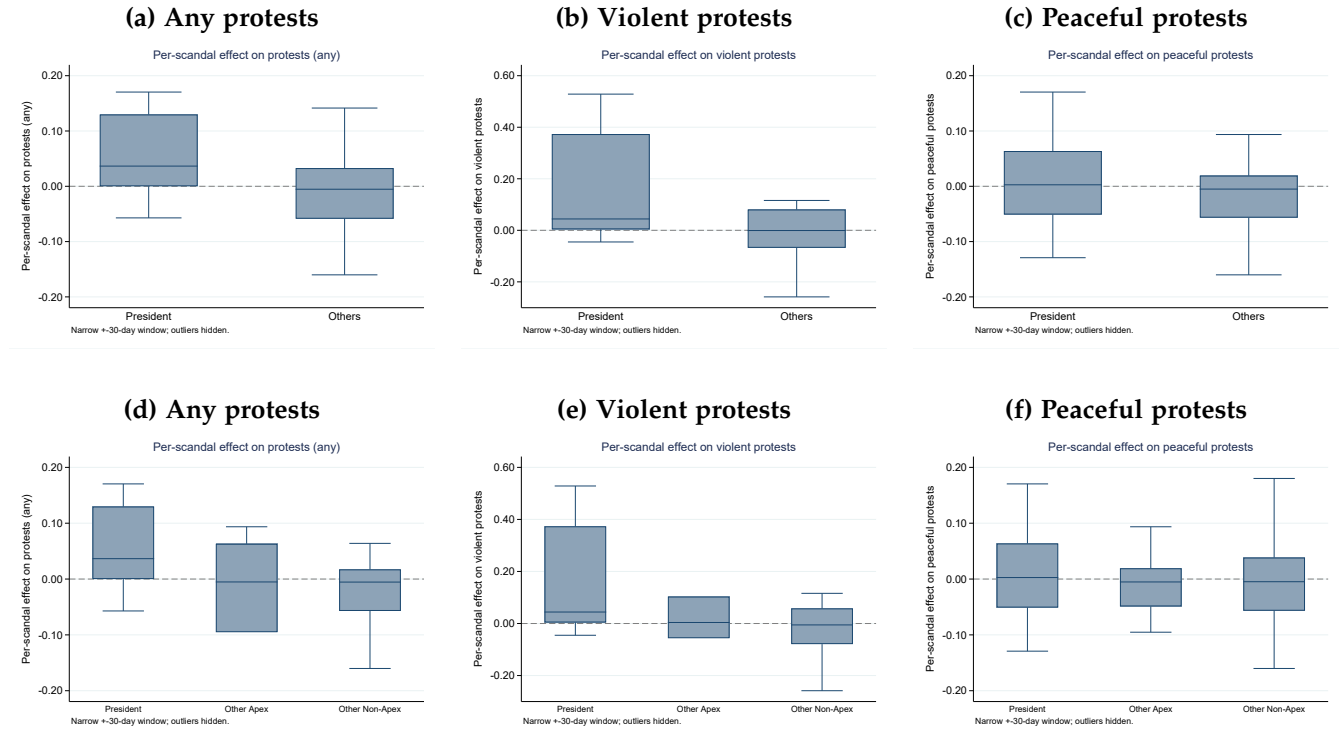


Figure 2. The protest response scales with the political rank of the implicated official. For each of the 176 scandals we estimate the OLS post-scandal coefficient on the ± 30 -day window of the implicated country, controlling for day-of-week and month. The cross-scandal distribution of these coefficients is summarized by box plot. *Top row:* President (45 scandals) against the pooled non-Presidential category (127 scandals; Governors, Congress, judicial actors, lower officials). *Bottom row:* the three-way apex partition—President, Other Apex (27 scandals; Governors and members of Congress), and Other Non-Apex (100 scandals; Supreme Court justices, lower judiciary, lower officials). Outliers are hidden for legibility.

4 Discussion

Three implications of our findings stand out as substantively important.

First, apex corruption is a high-frequency driver of political violence. The protest response begins within days of public disclosure and remains positive through at least four months. This is in sharp contrast to the electoral-accountability framing of much of the corruption-and-political-economy

literature, in which corruption matters because it shifts voting behavior at the next election (Ferraz and Finan 2011; Arias et al. 2019, 2022). By the time the next election arrives, the cumulative effect of multiple intervening apex scandals on the protest margin may already have shaped the political environment in which that election is held. The protest channel we document operates as a quicker, more responsive sibling of the electoral-accountability channel.

Second, the political rank of the implicated official is not an incidental moderator but the central source of variation. Scandals against sitting Presidents drive the bulk of the average response; scandals confined to Supreme Court justices and lower officials are indistinguishable from null. The asymmetry has substantive implications for the design of anti-corruption institutions: prosecutorial and disclosure investments targeting the apex have larger reverberations in the short-run political environment than equivalent investments at lower levels of the political hierarchy. The audit-report literature (Ferraz and Finan 2011; Arias et al. 2019) has shown that disclosures discipline behavior at the municipal level; our findings indicate that disclosures at the apex move the political environment on a different margin, and at a faster horizon, than the municipal-level disclosure apparatus can.

Third, our results connect to two ongoing research programs in political economy. The first is the literature on economic shocks as drivers of political violence (Miguel et al. 2004; McGuirk and Burke 2020; König et al. 2017; Rohner et al. 2026), which has emphasized income, commodity prices, and aid as the principal levers. Our findings add a political shock—the public disclosure of apex corruption—that operates at effect magnitudes comparable to the economic shocks the literature has documented. The second is parallel work on the attitudinal channel through which apex corruption operates (Rivera et al. 2024; Ajzenman 2021), which documents an analogous concentration of effects against the apex on stated support for democracy, costly civic engagement, and the honesty of routine social interactions. The convergence of behavioral and attitudinal results indicates that apex corruption operates through a coherent mechanism that affects both citizen beliefs and citizen actions; the protest channel we document is the visible manifestation of that mechanism at the level of the street.

Limitations. Three limitations are worth flagging explicitly. First, our identification rests on the timing of the public disclosure of scandals, not on the underlying acts of corruption. If apex-rank officials are disproportionately disclosed in periods of pre-existing political ferment—reverse causality through prosecutorial strategy or media salience—part of the effect we attribute to scandals could reflect the ferment that occasioned them. The pre-trend graphs of Figure 1 make the strongest version of this concern unlikely but cannot rule it out completely. Second, our protest counts are media-based: the Mass Mobilization project records protests that reach the press, and reporting intensity may vary across countries and over time within country. Independent validation against ACLED on

the 2018–2020 overlap (not shown) preserves the sign and significance of the headline result. Third, while the apex-rank asymmetry in [Figure 2](#) is consistent with a salience-of-stakeholder interpretation of the mechanism—in which mobilization responds to the political weight of what is disclosed, not the disclosure per se—we cannot distinguish this reading from one based on differential press coverage of high-rank versus low-rank scandals. The randomized field experiment in [Rivera et al. \(2024\)](#), which holds press coverage constant and varies only the rank of the agent shown to subjects, provides indirect evidence on this question.

An open question. The findings raise a constructive empirical question for follow-on work. If the protest channel responds to the political stakes citizens hold in the implicated agent, then interventions that align citizens’ stakes with peaceful political outcomes should attenuate the channel. The companion paper ([Rivera et al. 2024](#)) reports tentative evidence on this margin for the *attitudinal* consequences of apex scandals. Whether the behavioral mobilization we document here can be similarly attenuated—by stake-aligning instruments of a financial, civic, or institutional kind—is an open empirical question, and the natural next step.

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